

"No more tux, please"

It's fairly simple to cleanly remove Linux from your hard disk, and go back to single-boot Windows. This is a two step process: You first need to overwrite the partitions that Linux occupies on your hard drive, and then follow up by cleaning the MBR, if that's occupied by Linux.

First, determine your current boot loader. If it's NTLDR—and you're dual-booting using GRUB/LILO on the boot sector of the Linux partition—you don't have to bother with clearing MBR. If the boot loader is LILO, boot into Linux and run the `'lilo -u'` command to uninstall LILO.

To recover hard drive space from Linux, use the GNU fdisk tool, from the command line: `fdisk /dev/hda`.

(This is if you want to run fdisk on the `/dev/hda` hard drive.)

Next, choose the Linux partitions, both the file system one(s) and the swap partition, and delete them. For convenience, you can also choose to convert them into VFAT, or FAT32.

If you're running GRUB, or forgot to uninstall LILO, here's the way out. For Windows 98 users, once you have finished with the fdisk operation, use the Windows 98 bootable CD, or boot diskette to boot into Windows 98 and run `'fdisk /mbr'`, as explained earlier.

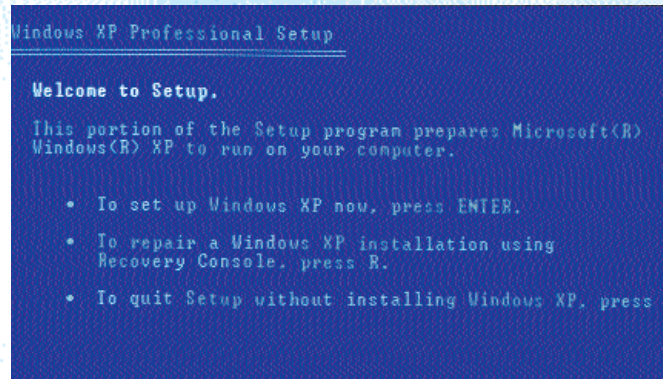
That's about it. Windows XP users will have to boot into Windows XP using the Windows XP boot CD. Press [R] during setup to activate the recovery console, and run the `'fixmbr'` command.

If you have the money to spare, we'd recommend that you invest in PowerQuest's Partition Magic 8. It's one of the best commercial tools for managing disk file systems, and do conversions between a variety of operating systems including Linux and FreeBSD, and all versions of Windows. Partition Magic's Boot Magic tool also manages multiple boots.

"I can't boot into Windows!"

For Windows XP users, GRUB is godsend. Unlike LILO, it allows for seamless dual-boots with Windows XP, and a wide variety of Linux and Unix OSes, without any additional tweaking. However, it's quite possible that you managed to destroy the MBR sufficiently enough—be it a virus or just another boot loader—that you can't boot into Windows. Before pressing the panic button, try reinstalling your boot loader.

It's quite possible that with your GRUB device mapping intact you may be able to boot into Windows XP. If you are really out of luck, you need to resort to loading in the Windows XP boot loader, NTLDR. Here's how: Insert the Windows XP bootable CD, and during setup, press [R] to initiate the recovery console. Locate the correct Windows installation that you want to recover—this



Next up, clicking 'R' takes you to the Recovery Console

neat and simple solution—boot using the Windows 98 CD or a Windows 98 bootable diskette, and run `'fdisk /mbr'` at the command prompt. This will overwrite the current MBR (GRUB or LILO) and allow for fast booting into Windows 98.

So what happens to Linux? For information on how to continue dual booting into Linux using the NTLDR, refer the February 2004 issue of *Digit*. With Windows 98, you may consider reinstalling GRUB on the MBR itself. In any case, remember that Linux needs a boot loader regardless of whether or not you're dual-booting. So you could choose to install a third-party booting utility such as XOSL in the MBR, and install GRUB (or LILO) in the boot sector of the Linux partition.

XOSL (www.xosl.org) is a free tool with a slick GUI and is highly recommended for dual-boots. Downloads may be problematic as the Web site appears to be down for a while now, so get a copy from an enlightened friend.

